CASE OF THE MISSING AMMO

- Maoists mostly use INSAS rifles and country-made guns but are dependent on security forces conduits for ammo supplies. A bullet goes for Rs 700
- Legally produced cartridges from state ordnance factories are diverted. But they can be traced; every cartridge carries a head stamp linking it to the factory
- Preliminary investigations suggest false documentation of number of rounds fired by the security forces to facilitate diversion of supplies to Maoists
- NCRB Crime in India Report 2020 says 95,265 rounds of ammunition seized in various raids

their own, rely on security forces conduits such as Awinash for their ammo requirements. The returns are impressive too. In an earlier transgression that Awinash admitted to during his interrogation while in judicial custody, he had passed on 250 live rounds of 5.56 mm cartridges for INSAS rifles to the Maoists for a consideration of Rs 1.75 lakh in 2020. His cut? Rs 750 per round.

NOT A ONE-OFF CASE

As the Jharkhand police dug deeper, it exposed the national scale of the gunrunning racket. On November 17, 2021, a joint team of the Bihar and Jharkhand Special Task Force (STF) arrested Arun Kumar Singh a.k.a. Fauji, a former BSF (Border Security Force) jawan, and recovered 919 live INSAS cartridges, an SLR (self-loading rifle) and a 9mm pistol from him. Arun was picked up from his home in Shahpur village in Bihar's Saran district.

Five days later, on November 22, a Jharkhand police team arrested BSF head constable Kartik Behra. Behra, who hails from Jharkhand's Seraikela-Kharsawan district, was posted in Ferozepur, Punjab, at the time of his arrest. He was one of the men in charge of the armoury at the BSF's 116 battalion, where Arun too was posted before he retired.) The police claimed they recovered a stockpile of "pilfered ammunition", including 8,304 cartridges, magazines and detonators, from Behra. Empty ammo boxes, too, were recovered— each with a thousand-bullet capacity—from Behra's house. This leads the police to believe that the actual number of ammo supplied to the Maoists is far more than what the arrested paramilitary personnel have confessed to providing.

Awinash had been arrested from his home in Bihar's Gaya district on November 13. Two other accomplices—Rishi Kumar and Pankaj Singh—were arrested from Bihar. Also implicated are contractors Mujaid Khan and Sanjay Singh—also from Seraikela-Kharsawan—who allegedly work closely with the CPI (Maoist). Awinash himself had joined the CRPF in August 2011 and has served in Jharkhand's Latehar and Chhattisgarh's Jagdalpur districts, both Maoist hotbeds. He was posted in Jammu but went on leave in July 2021 and had been AWOL since, till his arrest. Sources allege he had turned rogue at the instigation of Maoist sympathisers in Jharkhand.

Though the police are unwilling to go on record about the information that led them to Awinash, the timing of his arrest could hold a clue. Just two days earlier, on November 11, CPI (Maoist) politburo member Prashant Bose alias Kishanda and his wife Sheela Marandi, the first woman member of the Maoist Central Committee, had been arrested. Top police officers did hint at the time that they had struck on a motherlode of information from the 2 TB data card recovered from Kishanda. The Jharkhand police also made arrests in Maharashtra in connection with the case, recovering 14 semi-automatic pistols, 21 magazines and mobile phones.

Perhaps for the first time, the BSF admitted to lapses and said action was being taken against "defaulting individuals"

LAPSES IN THE ARMOURY

Police investigations point toward deficiencies in record-keeping and safeguarding of armoury ammunition and equipment. In an e-mail response to INDIA TODAY on March 29, a BSF spokesperson said disciplinary proceedings have been initiated against the "defaulting individuals who had been responsible for screening and monitoring of the armoury" and that "lapses (have been) identified and are being addressed accordingly". The CRPF, too, confirmed that a special audit was conducted at the armoury of 182 battalion in Jammu where Awinash was posted. "There was no shortfall in the armoury," DIG operations Sudhanshu Singh wrote back in answer to the queries. However, despite set guidelines, top officers of the Jharkhand police believe there is tremendous scope for improvement in the monitoring and cross-verification of data on increase/ decrease in inventory. The scale of missing inventory is possibly huge. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) 'Crime in India Report 2020' says 95,265 rounds of live ammunition were seized in various raids conducted that year.

The police are also checking if documents had been forged to pilfer ammunition. "There are signs of false documentation of firing of rounds during operations," a top police source in Jharkhand discloses. "There is also evidence of supplies coming from the BSF campuses in Jodhpur and Jaisalmer. More paramilitary personnel could be involved in bypassing the system of cataloguing and storing ammunition." Transactions were also allegedly made in Punjab, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Maharashtra and Bihar.

OVER TO THE NIA

On December 3, 2021, the Union ministry of home affairs ordered the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to take up the case. "The Jharkhand police was on the verge of exposing the entire network that supplies arms—such as INSAS, AK-47 and 9mm rifles—and ammunition to terrorist organisations. But given the exhaustive nature of the investigation and its spread across many states, the Centre has handed over the case to the NIA," a senior